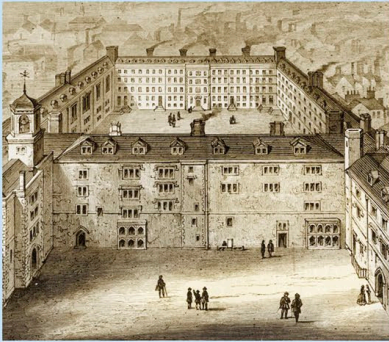




Bridewell Prison, depicted in 1720. At this time, it housed petty criminals and pauper apprentices, as well as vagrants and others deemed to be the “idle” poor.

Bridewell Prison

The original “house of correction,” Bridewell Prison in London started life as Bridewell Palace, one of the homes of Henry VIII. In 1553, Edward VI, Henry’s son, gave the decaying palace to the City of London Corporation to be used as an orphanage and a place of “correction” for “disorderly” women—that is, prostitutes. By 1556, part of the site had become Bridewell Prison. After the 1601 Poor Law Act, it became the template for the idea of the “short, sharp shock” for those unwilling

to work or guilty of minor crimes. Bridewell combined prison, hospital, and workhouse, where inmates were forced to carry out hard labor. Regular punishments included public whippings twice a week.

Bridewell was the model for future houses of correction, which in turn were often referred to as a “Bridewell.” The prison burned down in the 1666 Great Fire of London but was quickly rebuilt and remained in use until the 1860s.

people to stay in their homes. They were then given money, known as a “dole,” or help in kind, such as clothes or food. Indoor relief compelled the homeless poor into almshouses (charity-run houses), orphanages, or houses of correction, where people would be set to work.

The poor who were “lame, impotent, old, blind,” and therefore unable to work were provided either with outdoor relief or a place in an almshouse or hospital. The able-bodied poor with no home might be sent to a “house of industry”—the prototype for the later workhouses—where they were provided with raw materials and made to work. Conditions in these places were deliberately kept harsh in order, it was argued, to act as a deterrent to falling into poverty and relying on public support.

Vagabonds and the “idle” poor (those branded as unwilling to work) were sent to a house of correction, which was a much harsher option. Here, they were forced into hard labor, such as beating hemp plants to make rope.

The effectiveness of the Poor Law Act’s provisions varied widely from parish to parish. Some parishes

were generous to the poor, while others were mean, and many tried to pass on their responsibility by shifting poor people to other parishes. The 1601 Act did, however, establish the precedent of providing a basic level of support for people in the direst poverty, and for more than two centuries, this was the one safety net for those at the bottom of society.

Punishment of poverty

Despite the principle of charity at its core, the poor law system was a double-edged sword. It aimed to punish poverty as much as to support it and to be harsh enough to prevent a reliance on poor relief.

The issue of poverty as a crime came to the fore as the Industrial Revolution began in Britain in the late 18th century and city populations grew. Industrialists needed workers for their factories, and laborers were required to work the land in order to feed the increasing numbers. Philosopher, jurist, and social reformer Jeremy Bentham was particularly insistent that poor relief should be framed to discipline and punish slackers. Meanwhile, political economist David Ricardo argued that any kind

of poor relief undermined “the iron law of wages,” in which wages were paid according to demand.

These ideas paved the way for a new Poor Law Act in 1834, which ended outdoor relief, replacing it with a system of workhouses where tough conditions were imposed to act as a deterrent. The workhouse was the stuff of nightmares, as depicted so vividly by Charles Dickens in his novel *Oliver Twist*. It took more than 100 years of campaigning before workhouses were abolished and replaced with a modern welfare system in 1948. ■

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[The 1834 Poor Law Amendment Act] announces to the world that in England poverty is a crime.

Benjamin Disraeli

UK prime minister
(1868, 1874–1880)

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